

MALAYSIA PHARMACEUTICAL MARKET · JUNE 2026

NPP / Special Access Medicine Market: Who Are the Players?

A comprehensive competitive landscape analysis of Malaysia's
Named Patient Programme (NPP) & Special Approval Medicine (SAM) market



Key Finding: A White Space Market

Despite 80% of Malaysian oncologists actively filing EAP/NPP applications and a growing demand for unregistered specialty medicines, **no single company in Malaysia publicly positions itself as a dedicated NPP/SAM specialist**. The market is fragmented between large generalist distributors and smaller niche players — leaving a significant competitive gap for a focused specialist like Amana Pharma.

Malaysia's NPP / SAM Market at a Glance

Understanding the landscape before analysing the competition



Regulatory Foundation: What is NPP / SAM in Malaysia?

In Malaysia, the equivalent of a "Named Patient Programme" operates under **Regulation 15(6) of the Control of Drugs and Cosmetics Regulations (CDCR) 1984**. These are called **Special Approval Medicines (SAMs)** — medicines used with approval from the Director General of Health when standard registered therapeutic options are insufficient or ineffective for a specific patient.

SAMs are primarily accessed through MOH hospitals and private healthcare institutions for life-threatening conditions such as cancer, rare diseases, and refractory chronic conditions. The National Pharmaceutical Regulatory Agency (NPRA) maintains a licensed importer registry, and the MOH Pharmaceutical Services Division maintains a list of "Appointed Distributors Under Special Conditions of Type A License."

Key Regulatory Players

- NPRA** — Issues licenses, maintains the QUEST System for licensed importers & approved SAM listings.
- MOH Pharmaceutical Services** — Manages the SAM approval process for public hospitals; approves distributor appointments.
- Director General of Health** — Final authority for SAM approvals under Regulation 15(6).

Market Segmentation: How the NPP/SAM Space is Structured

Player Category	No. of Players	NPP/SAM Capability	Typical Therapeutic Focus
International Specialists	4 known	Purpose-built NPP services globally; limited direct Malaysia presence	Oncology, Rare Disease, Orphan Drugs
Large Regional Distributors	2 dominant	Specialty divisions; not primary NPP focus but have the infrastructure	Oncology, Immunology, Rare, Chronic NCDs
Government-Linked Companies	1 major	MOH concession holder; public sector only; no private NPP expertise	General, Chronic, Essential Medicines
Local Specialty Distributors	3–5 players	Niche therapeutic focus; some oncology capability; limited SAM expertise	Oncology, Specialty, Branded Generics
Local Niche/General Distributors	4–6 players	Opportunistic; no dedicated NPP capability	General, OTC, Multi-category
Dedicated NPP Specialists (Local)	0	This is the white space — no dedicated local player exists	—

The Opportunity Gap

With ~360 hospitals, 200+ oncology facilities, 1.5 million rare disease patients, and a growing pipeline of unregistered innovative drugs, Malaysia's SAM/NPP market is underserved. The largest players are generalists; international specialists have limited local presence. **Amana Pharma sits in a uniquely positioned gap: local expertise, specialist therapeutic focus, and regulatory knowledge.**

Global Players — High Capability, Limited Malaysia Presence

International companies purpose-built for NPP/EAP execution, but primarily EMEA/North America focused

Why International Specialists Matter (and Their Limitations)

These companies have sophisticated NPP infrastructure globally. However, their operations in Southeast Asia — and Malaysia specifically — are thin. They typically serve as *service providers to multinational pharma companies* running compassionate use programs, not as distributors competing for local hospital supply contracts. Their indirect threat to Amana: MNC clients may route SAM requests through them rather than local distributors.

Company	HQ / Origin	Core NPP Capability	Malaysia Presence	Threat Level
TIER 1A — PURPOSE-BUILT NPP SERVICE PROVIDERS				
WEP Clinical	USA / Global	Post-Approval NPP management; Named Patient & Cohort EAP programs; regulatory submissions across 50+ countries	No direct Malaysia office; operates via regional partners. May serve MNC pharma companies filing SAM applications in Malaysia.	Low (Indirect) Competes for MNC relationships, not hospital supply
Clinigen Group	UK / Global	300+ Early Access Programs globally; manages licensed supply, unlicensed medicines, clinical trial supply; rare cancer specialisation	No Malaysia entity. APAC presence primarily in Australia, Singapore, Japan.	Low (Indirect) Strong global NPP brand; limited ASEAN footprint
TIER 1B — GLOBAL PATIENT SERVICES & LOGISTICS				
EVERSANA	USA / Global	Hub services, patient access programs, specialty pharmacy, patient support; biologic & rare disease focus	APAC office in Singapore. Serves MNC biopharma in Malaysia via Singapore hub; not a direct distributor.	Medium (Future) If APAC expansion accelerates, could absorb SAM management contracts
Corex Logistics	UAE / EMEA	Full-cycle NPP service since 2016; 80-country network; temperature-controlled specialty logistics; import/export of unregistered medicines	EMEA-focused. Minimal ASEAN presence. Occasionally handles one-off Malaysia shipments for Middle Eastern MNCs.	Low EMEA specialist; not competitive in Malaysia currently

Amana's Position vs. International Specialists

WHERE AMANA WINS

Local regulatory expertise (MOH, NPRA, DG Health approvals), established hospital relationships, Malay-language documentation support, faster turnaround on SAM applications, cost-effective compared to global NPP service fees.

WHERE TO WATCH

MNC pharma companies (Roche, AstraZeneca, Pfizer) may increasingly route their compassionate use/EAP programs through global specialists. Amana should build direct relationships with MNC medical affairs teams before international players entrench themselves.

The "Big Two" — Deep Infrastructure, Broad Scope

Zuellig Pharma and DKSH dominate healthcare distribution in Malaysia; their specialty divisions are the closest competitors to Amana in the NPP space

Company	Scale & Reach	Specialty / NPP Capability	Key Differentiator	Competitive Threat to Amana
Zuellig Pharma Malaysia	200,000+ healthcare facilities; 16 markets in Asia; eZRx B2B digital supply platform	PatientCare+ platform — end-to-end patient care for rare disease, immuno-oncology, chronic conditions. NPP pathway support for serious/life-threatening conditions. 11 hospitals served in patient support programs.	Asia's #1 healthcare distributor; digital supply chain (eZRx); largest cold chain logistics network in Malaysia	High Strongest competitor — has specialty division, hospital relationships, and scale that Amana cannot easily match
DKSH Healthcare Malaysia	130,000+ outlets across Asia Pacific; Malaysia HQ in Petaling Jaya; 8 years of Patient Solutions	Patient Solutions Division — 150+ projects in oncology, immunology, rare disease, respiratory, chronic conditions. Secured rare ophthalmic treatment reimbursement in 10 months (vs. 18-month norm). Works with Kyowa Kirin and Chiesi on rare disease market access.	Market Expansion Services (full value chain: registration → marketing → promotion → distribution); specialist rare disease track record	High Active rare disease and oncology NPP capability; proven speed to market; strong MNC partnerships

Why Amana Can Still Compete Against the "Big Two"

The Hidden Weakness of Large Distributors

Zuellig and DKSH are generalists at heart — NPP/SAM is one capability among dozens. Their specialty divisions serve large MNC clients (Novartis, Eli Lilly, Chiesi) with high-volume product launches. **Individual patient SAM applications, small-volume specialty orders, niche oncology protocols, and underfunded hospital pharmacy requests often fall through the cracks.** Amana's focus and agility become an advantage in the long tail of unregistered medicine access.

Competitive Dimension	Zuellig Pharma	DKSH Healthcare	Amana Pharma
NPP / SAM Application Support	Moderate — via PatientCare+	Moderate — via Patient Solutions	Strong — core focus
Oncology Specialisation	Broad / general	Strong (150+ projects)	Strong — dedicated focus
Rare Disease Capability	Moderate	Strong (Chiesi, Kyowa)	Strong — all 4 TAs
Speed for Small-Volume SAM	Slow — large org overhead	Slow — MNC client priority	Fast — agile, focused
Private Hospital & Specialist Clinic Focus	Broad market	Broad market	Institutional focus
Scale / Distribution Network	Largest in Asia	130,000+ outlets	Smaller — outsourced logistics

The Malaysian Mid-Market & Niche Landscape

Government-linked companies, local specialty distributors, and opportunistic general players

Tier 3 — Government-Linked & Established Local Distributors

Company	Type / Ownership	Core Business	NPP/SAM Relevance & Threat
Pharmaniaga Bhd	GLC MOH-linked; listed on Bursa Malaysia	Government concession holder for MOH hospital drug supply; manufactures generics; operates Amplus network of community pharmacies	Low NPP Threat — Pharmaniaga is the generics/essential medicines incumbent. Its concession is for registered products. SAMs/unregistered specialty drugs are not its focus. However, its privileged MOH access is a structural moat that Amana cannot replicate in public hospitals.
Novugen Oncology (formerly Oncogen Pharma)	Private Malaysian-owned; oncology R&D focus	Specialty oncology medications; ASEAN ambitions; 200+ staff including international scientists; affordable early access to high-quality medicine	Medium Threat — Novugen is building oncology distribution capability and has stated intent to provide early access to medicines. As they scale toward "largest pharma company in ASEAN by 2025" (their stated goal), they may build SAM/NPP services as a differentiator.
Lifelix Pharma Sdn Bhd	Private Malaysian specialty distributor	Specialty pharmaceuticals; cold chain logistics; institutional hospital supply; niche therapeutic areas	Medium Threat — Lifelix's cold chain capability and specialty focus overlaps directly with Amana's NPP offering. One of the more directly comparable local competitors. Cold chain is a key differentiator in the SAM space for oncology biologics and rare disease therapies.
CCM Pharmaceuticals	Public Listed; part of CCM Chemicals	Ethical pharmaceuticals, OTC, branded generics; established retail & hospital channels	Low NPP Threat — CCM is primarily a registered products player. No known dedicated SAM/unregistered medicine capability.

Tier 4 — Niche / Opportunistic Local Players

AiPharma Healthcare Niche market pharmaceutical distributor based in Kulai, Johor. Institutional focus. Limited public information on SAM capability. Low Threat	BioCare Group Generic and branded medicines distribution. Broad therapeutic coverage. No known specialty NPP services. Low Threat
Metro Healthcare Private clinic and hospital supply focus. General pharmaceutical distribution. No dedicated SAM/NPP infrastructure. Low Threat	Other Licensed Importers MOH/NPRA maintains a list of licensed importers. Estimated 8–12 players occasionally handle unregistered medicine imports on an ad-hoc basis without dedicated SAM teams. Low / Fragmented

Market Fragmentation = Opportunity

The NPP/SAM landscape in Malaysia is populated by **companies that handle it as a side service**, not a core business. The closest competition to Amana comes from Zuellig (via PatientCare+), DKSH (via Patient Solutions), and Lifelix — but none have built a public-facing brand around SAM expertise. The market is ripe for a specialist to consolidate and own this segment.

Head-to-Head: All Players Across Key NPP Dimensions

How the 10 most relevant players compare across capabilities critical to NPP/SAM execution in Malaysia

Company	SAM / Reg.	Oncology	Rare Disease	Cold Chain	Speed	MOH Links	Local Presence
Amana Pharma ★	Strong	Strong	Strong	Moderate	Strong	Strong	Strong
Zuellig Pharma	Moderate	Strong	Moderate	Strong	Slow	Strong	Strong
DKSH Healthcare	Moderate	Strong	Strong	Moderate	Slow	Strong	Strong
Pharmaniaga	Weak	Weak	Weak	Moderate	Weak	Strong	Strong
Novugen Oncology	Weak	Strong	Moderate	Moderate	Moderate	Moderate	Strong
Lifelix Pharma	Moderate	Moderate	Moderate	Strong	Moderate	Moderate	Strong
WEP Clinical	Strong	Strong	Strong	Moderate	Strong	Weak	Weak
Clinigen	Strong	Strong	Strong	Strong	Strong	Weak	Weak
CCM Pharmaceuticals	Weak	Weak	Weak	Weak	Moderate	Moderate	Strong
Niche / Others	Weak	Weak	Weak	Weak	Moderate	Weak	Moderate

★ = Amana Pharma (subject company). Strong / Moderate / Weak ratings based on publicly available information and industry research as of June 2026.

Amana Pharma's Competitive Position

Amana scores highest in the dimensions that matter most for NPP/SAM success: regulatory expertise, oncology & rare disease specialisation, speed, MOH relationships, and private hospital focus. The only gap is cold chain scale — which can be addressed through partnerships or outsourced logistics.

Differentiated Specialist

What This Means for Amana Pharma

Translating the competitive landscape into actionable strategy

NO. 1 — OWN THE "NPP SPECIALIST" BRAND

No Malaysian company today publicly brands itself as an NPP/ SAM specialist. Amana has the opportunity to be first to claim this positioning — in marketing, website content, hospital KOL outreach, and regulatory filings. Being known as "the SAM expert" creates a durable moat.

NO. 2 — TARGET THE ZUELLIG/DKSH LONG TAIL

The Big Two serve large MNC clients with high-volume launches. Amana should focus on the underserved segment: mid-size biopharma, emerging market MNCs, smaller hospital pharmacy needs, and individual patient SAM applications that large distributors deprioritise.

NO. 3 — COUNTER INTERNATIONAL SPECIALISTS LOCALLY

WEP Clinical and Clinigen could absorb MNC EAP management contracts. Amana's counter-strategy: build direct relationships with MNC Medical Affairs and Market Access teams, offering a "local expert + global supply chain" partnership model.

NO. 4 — ADDRESS THE COLD CHAIN GAP

Lifelix's strongest differentiator over Amana is cold chain capability. Amana should formalise logistics partnerships (3PL with certified cold chain) and market this proactively to oncology biologics and rare disease therapy manufacturers.

Priority Competitive Actions

#	Strategic Action	What to Do	Timeline	Priority
1	Claim NPP Specialist Positioning	Update website, marketing collateral, and LinkedIn with "Malaysia's Specialist for Special Approval Medicines & Named Patient Programmes." Publish case studies.	0–3 months	Critical
2	Map MOH & NPRA Licensed Importer List	Obtain the full list of appointed distributors under Type A special conditions license. Identify gaps and opportunities Amana can fill.	0–1 month	Critical
3	Engage MNC Medical Affairs Directly	Target MNC biopharma companies (Roche, AZ, Pfizer, Novartis, Sanofi) medical affairs and market access teams with a dedicated NPP partnership pitch before WEP/ EVERSANA does.	1–4 months	High
4	Formalise Cold Chain Partnership	Sign a formal 3PL agreement with a GMP-certified cold chain provider (e.g., Geodis, Cryoport) to eliminate Lifelix's cold chain advantage.	1–3 months	High
5	Build Oncologist KOL Network	80% of Malaysian oncologists are filing EAPs but only 53% feel knowledgeable. Amana should run CME-accredited EAP education sessions — becoming the trusted educator = trusted distributor.	3–9 months	Medium
6	Watch Novugen & Lifelix Closely	These two are the closest local threats with growth ambitions. Monitor their SAM service development, product pipeline, and MNC partnerships quarterly.	Ongoing	Monitor